

Question ID: f09097b1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Algebra	Linear equations in one variable	Medium

Question

An agricultural scientist studying the growth of corn plants recorded the height of a corn plant at the beginning of a study and the height of the plant each day for the next 12 days. The scientist found that the height of the plant increased by an average of 1.20 centimeters per day for the 12 days. If the height of the plant on the last day of the study was 36.8 centimeters, what was the height, in centimeters, of the corn plant at the beginning of the study?

Rationale

The correct answer is 22.4. If the height of the plant increased by an average of 1.20 centimeters per day for 12 days, then its total growth over the 12 days was $(1.20)(12) = 14.4$ centimeters. The plant was 36.8 centimeters tall after 12 days, so at the beginning of the study its height was $36.8 - 14.4 = 22.4$ centimeters. Note that 22.4 and $11\frac{2}{5}$ are examples of ways to enter a correct answer.

Alternate approach: The equation $36.8 = 12(1.20) + h$ can be used to represent this situation, where h is the height of the plant, in centimeters, at the beginning of the study. Solving this equation for h yields 22.4 centimeters.